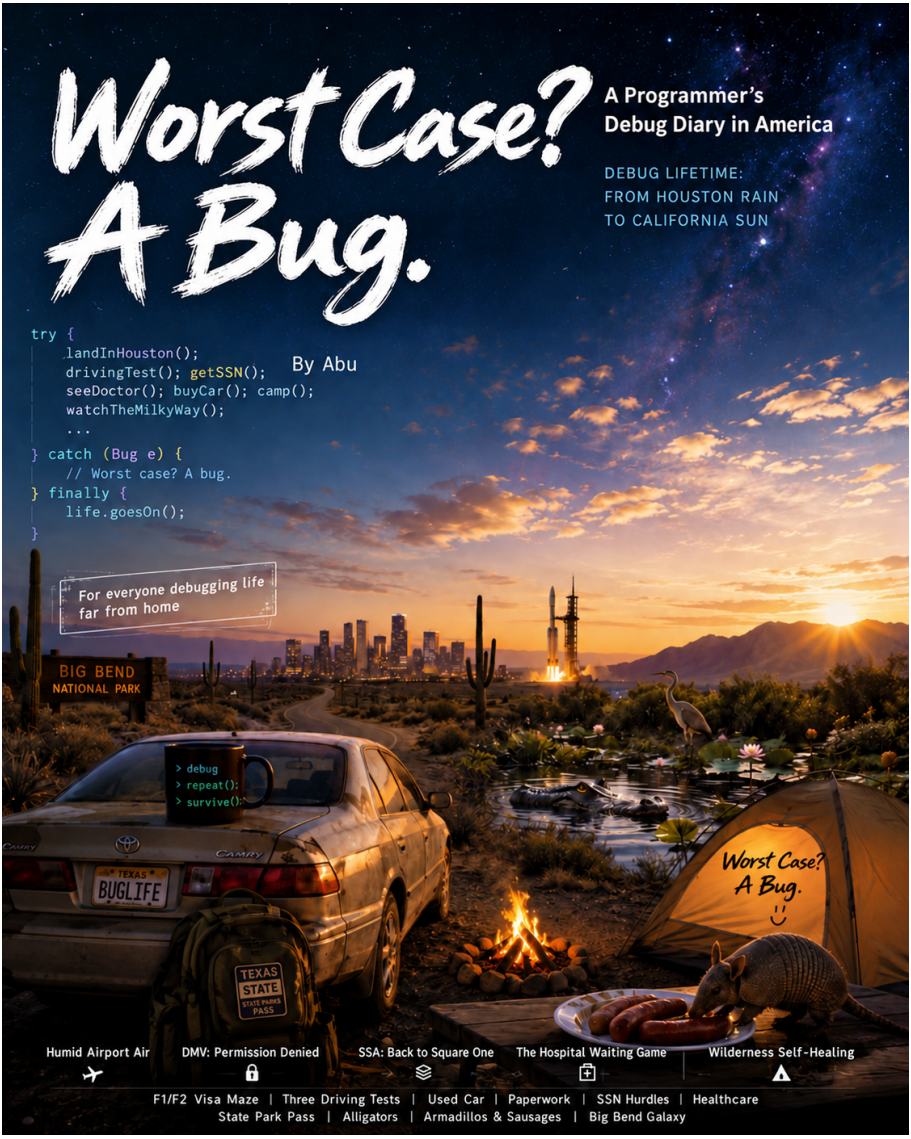

Worst Case? A Bug.
A Programmer's Debug Diary in America
DEBUG LIFETIME: FROM HOUSTON RAIN TO CALIFORNIA SUN
try {
landInHouston();
drivingTest(); getSSN();
seeDoctor(); buyCar(); camp();
watchTheMilkyWay();
...
} catch (Bug e) {
// Worst case? A bug.
} finally {
life.goesOn();
}
By Abu
For everyone debugging life far from home
BIG BEND NATIONAL PARK
> debug
> repeat();
> survive();
TEXAS BUGLIFE
TEXAS STATE STATE PARKS PASS
Worst Case? A Bug.
Humid Airport Air
DMV: Permission Denied
SSA: Back to Square One
The Hospital Waiting Game
Wilderness Self-Healing
F1/F2 Visa Maze | Three Driving Tests | Used Car | Paperwork | SSN Hurdles | Healthcare
State Park Pass | Alligators | Armadillos & Sausages | Big Bend Galaxy

# Worst Case, a Bug

## Restarting Our Life in North America

By Abu

English translation draft · October 2026

This essay draft was developed from the author's experiences and book outline and awaits chapter-by-chapter review. It is not a podcast transcript, and no on-the-scene dialogue has been invented. References to immigration status, paperwork and healthcare describe individual experiences at the time, rather than current rules or instructions. Medical costs and appointment availability are specific to those experiences.

# Contents

Preface: Life Comes Without a Manual

Chapter 1: Landing in Houston: The Heat Told Me Life Had Reset

Chapter 2: F2: A Visible Status with Very Little Access

Chapter 3: The First Supports of Daily Life: A Hotel, an Empty Apartment and a Meal

Chapter 4: The Five-in-the-Morning Bus: Applying for a Learner Permit

Chapter 5: Three Driving Tests: Doing It Was Not Enough to Be Seen

Chapter 6: A Thirteen-Year-Old Camry: Finally, Legs of Our Own

Chapter 7: Insurance, Title and Registration: Even Freedom Needed Paperwork

Chapter 8: SSN Recursive Errors: Four Trips to the SSA in the Second Academic Year

Chapter 9: Houston, We Have a Problem: The Rocket That Came Back Scarred

Chapter 10: A Thirty-Five-Dollar Specialist Visit: Learning to Read the Body's Log

Chapter 11: The Little Brown Bottle: Healthcare Ended at the Supermarket Pharmacy

Chapter 12: Finding Healthcare on F2: The Next Appointment Was Next Year

Chapter 13: The Whatever Doctor and the Importance of a PCP

Chapter 14: Texas State Parks: Bluebonnets, Alligator Marshes and an Armadillo After the Sausages

Chapter 15: Big Bend: A Leaking Air Mattress Beneath the Milky Way

Chapter 16: Leaving Texas: From a Small Town Toward California

Afterword: Not Every Bug Needs Fixing

Preface

# Life Comes Without a Manual

When I first arrived in America, I thought I needed to adjust to the language, weather, transport, healthcare, bills and all the rules. Learn them one at a time, I imagined, and life would begin to run smoothly. Later I realized that what I really had to get used to was living without a manual.

My old experience had not disappeared. I simply could not always find the right place to use it. An action I once performed without thinking now involved research, paperwork, phone calls and waiting for a reply. I did not know which step would fail, or which counter would send me back.

When writing software, I was used to locating a problem and working out a fix. In life, a problem rarely arrived with clear boundaries. Sometimes I had misunderstood. Sometimes the rules differed from my expectations. Sometimes the system simply was not working that day. Getting something wrong and being unable to do it yet could look remarkably alike.

This is neither a technical book nor a guide to avoiding trouble in North America. These routes cannot simply be retraced: documents change, rules change, and the doctor, clerk or stretch of weather each person encounters will be different. What I want to keep is the experience of slowly learning to hold my own life together while those things were happening.

Beginning as an F2 accompanying spouse, I learned to make a home, then to get out, navigate paperwork and look after our health. Eventually life contained more than problems to solve. There were parks, camping trips, wild places and a sky that could stop me simply by making me look up.

Life is not a piece of perfect code. It is closer to finding your way through an unfamiliar system, making repairs as you go and continuing forward. I can write about these things not because I have understood everything, but because, after living through them, I can finally begin to tell the story.

Chapter 1

# Landing in Houston: The Heat Told Me Life Had Reset

The plane landed in Houston while the fatigue of the long journey was still in my body. Through immigration, baggage collection and finding our way, my movements seemed to follow the process while my mind lagged a beat behind. It was the humid heat that finally made arrival tangible. Even the air here was different.

The heat did not pass in a single gust. It clung to my skin like a warm, damp towel wrapped around my body. My luggage was beside me, but my internal clock had not quite caught up. I knew I had arrived; I did not yet know the rhythm in which I was supposed to live.

English changed shape at the same moment. It was no longer a listening exercise I could replay. It was an airport announcement, an immigration question, a word on a sign, something I had to catch immediately. If I missed it, the other person's day kept moving while I needed several more seconds to think.

What unsettled me most was not a single major event. Every small task had temporarily lost its familiarity. Before, I could read a sign and know where to go. Now I had to recognize the words, work out their meaning and confirm that I had not taken the wrong direction. Connections and long flights made each hesitation feel larger.

I had not yet encountered the counters, bills and appointments that would come later. But unfamiliarity was already beside me. It came without a checklist, hiding in every movement that required another moment of confirmation: from now on, many things would have to be learned again.

I had not simply moved to another city. I felt as though I had been placed inside an entirely unfamiliar operating system. Even the air was new.

Chapter 2

# F2: A Visible Status with Very Little Access

Soon after arriving in America, I learned to introduce my status as F2. Two characters, quick to say, yet in many situations they arrived before I did. They explained why I was here and often determined where a task could begin.

My husband had classes and university arrangements. His life was quickly caught by one timetable after another. My time appeared freer, yet I struggled to find somewhere for it to land. University resources largely revolved around students; I was not their default user. Some places were open to me, some required another question, and some entrances did not face me at all.

The restriction on working removed a familiar coordinate from my days. Nobody expected me to leave home each morning, and no progress chart told me how far I had come. When someone asked what I had been doing, I had to consider whether all these small matters of daily life counted as an answer.

This was not an absence of all freedom. The apparent abundance of time made the feeling of remaining on the edge harder to explain. I could arrange my day, but I could not reuse the old ways of proving that I was moving forward. Being legally present and having a main entrance were not the same thing.

It took time to separate the boundaries of my status from the boundaries of myself. A system's failure to reserve a place for me did not mean I could only wait. Grocery shopping, language learning, driving practice and getting to know new places began to fill my days. They had no single name, but they were changing my life.

At first I thought F2 was a supporting identity. Gradually I understood that a system could give me a label, but I would have to write my own life again.

Chapter 3

# The First Supports of Daily Life: A Hotel, an Empty Apartment and a Meal

For the first few days, our life was temporarily stored in a hotel. We opened our suitcases, took out what we needed and put things back. Our first burger meal cost twenty dollars per person and gave me a direct introduction to prices here. My mind was still converting everything; even an ordinary meal required adjustment.

Moving into the apartment made starting from zero clearer than the hotel had. The rooms were empty. There was no bed, table or chair. Once the door closed, our luggage seemed to be the most complete piece of furniture. We had rented a place, but a home had not yet grown inside it.

Sleeping on the floor made many abstract choices concrete. Before deciding how a room should look, we needed somewhere to sleep. Before thinking about a kitchen's style, we needed to cook a meal. We bought things little by little from Amazon and the supermarket. With each arrival, daily life gained another place to stand.

At HEB, I felt illiterate again. It was not that I could read none of the words. Familiar food had changed its packaging, units and location on the shelves. Pounds, gallons, Fahrenheit and miles added an extra calculation to numbers that once needed no translation.

A supermarket trip was more than completing a shopping list. It was learning again how to judge enough, expensive and suitable for our kitchen. Many hours went into these tasks. They were difficult to put in a progress report, but they were what actually allowed life to begin working.

When I looked back at that apartment, emptiness was no longer all I remembered. A life does not settle into place at once. It begins with a bed, a pot, a bag of rice and a lamp, slowly growing its own edges.

Chapter 4

# The Five-in-the-Morning Bus: Applying for a Learner Permit

Without a car in a small Texas town, distance demands attention. Two points that look close on a map may not be easily connected on foot. The bus timetable does not bend around your plans either. Before I could widen the radius of my life, I needed to learn how to move.

On the day I went to apply for a learner permit, I had to begin preparing for the bus at five in the morning. The roads were quiet. A task I associated with daytime began before the day had fully woken. Leaving early did not mean it would finish quickly; it was simply one part I could prepare.

Passport, I-20, I-94 and proof of address: I checked the documents I had gathered over and over. Each piece of paper was small, yet missing one could make the journey pointless. I was not yet good at knowing what a counter would truly care about, so I tried to bring everything I could think of.

Learning traffic rules was learning another language of this place. Stop signs, school buses and yield signs were no longer vocabulary to translate. Each called for an action and defined my place among other people on the road. Choosing a correct answer and understanding the road were connected, but separate, steps.

After the computer test, I received the paper permit. I did not suddenly have a car, and I still could not drive my life outward alone. But that sheet made the next step visible. I could begin practicing. Routes I had only imagined might one day become roads I could take.

In Texas, the permit was more than a piece of paper. It felt like the first message the system had sent me: now you can begin learning how to move.

Chapter 5

# Three Driving Tests: Doing It Was Not Enough to Be Seen

I went for the driving test three times. Looking back, a single number seems enough to contain the experience. At the time, each attempt meant preparing again, arriving, waiting and taking the result home. On a day I did not pass, the next opportunity did not appear automatically.

The first problem involved the lights and brake lights. Before the car had properly entered the test route, we were stopped. I had prepared to demonstrate driving; the car was examined first. The disappointment of finishing before I had started was difficult to know what to do with.

The second time, the problem finally reached me. My stop at a stop sign was not clear enough, and neither were my checks to the left and right. Feeling that I had paid attention did not mean the examiner could verify it from my movements. Safety had to exist outside my mind, where someone else could see it.

That changed my understanding of the test. It was not only asking whether I could operate a car. It was asking whether I could communicate through clear, steady actions: I had noticed the risk and knew what to do next. An imprecise habit became a very specific problem in the test.

I passed on the third attempt. That did not make the first two feel worthwhile, and I did not need to insist that every setback carried a special meaning. I had simply made the vehicle checks, stops and observations clearer, one by one. Passing was the accumulation of those concrete actions.

Often, doing something is not enough. You also have to let the system see that you have done it.

Chapter 6

# A Thirteen-Year-Old Camry: Finally, Legs of Our Own

Before buying a car, we watched graduating students' group chats for used-car listings. Looking at a car meant considering its price, age and history alongside our budget. No option felt entirely reassuring. We could only rule out problems gradually and decide which imperfections we were willing to accept.

What finally entered our life was a thirteen-year-old Camry. We had it checked before buying, but an inspection could not make an old car new. When we received the keys, anticipation and unease arrived together. It was finally ours, along with responsibilities we did not yet understand.

Finding a crack in the glass after the purchase made the meaning of a used car more concrete. Some details only emerge through daily use. You think the purchase is finished, but getting to know the car has just begun. Its sounds, condition and points that need attention all have to be learned.

Later, a flat tire revealed signs of an old collision and repainting near the right rear wheel. We had not lived through that history, but it remained in the car. A used car is not a discounted new one. It is a history that has already been running for years.

Yet it really did carry our life farther. Places that once required a look at the bus timetable could now be reached on our own schedule. Luggage and shopping had somewhere to go. Parks and distant cities were no longer only names on a map. The worries remained, but our ability to act had undeniably grown.

We had not bought a perfect car. We had bought an old system carrying its past. But it could start, take to the road and bring us farther than before.

Chapter 7

# Insurance, Title and Registration: Even Freedom Needed Paperwork

Having a car did not mean we could drive without concern. The keys were in our hands, but insurance, a title transfer and registration still awaited us. Completing something we had wanted for a long time did not lead to an empty space. It led to the next checklist.

Insurance quotes for a new driver hurt. The individual options looked recognizable, yet together I did not know how to compare them. How much to spend, how much risk to carry and what suited how often we drove all required thought.

Eventually we chose an arrangement that fit us at the time. The decision did not suddenly make me an expert. It meant gradually clarifying the important questions: how we used the car, what needed covering and what we could afford.

Title and registration were another set of words to learn. The car was not simply something we had bought. It also had to correspond to a person, an address, a signature and a record. At the county tax office, documents, queues, payments and waiting showed me that ownership had a paper process too.

I began to see these procedures as more than unnecessary obstacles before departure. They were frustrating and time-consuming, of course. But here, a car's ownership and use did not become recognized by every system simply because two people exchanged keys. Completion in our minds and completion in the records were still some distance apart.

Freedom did not arrive with a turn of the key. It also needed insurance, registration, an address, signatures and one sheet of paper after another that the system would accept.

Chapter 8

# SSN Recursive Errors: Four Trips to the SSA in the Second Academic Year

The SSN experience happened in the second academic year. By then, I was no longer in the state I had been in when I stepped off the plane. Many routines had become more familiar. I thought this task would mean preparing the documents, visiting a counter and waiting. It turned out to require four trips.

There was an issue with an ink signature, and there was a server outage. When I heard a result, my first thought was often that I had failed to prepare something. Discovering that not every problem was mine made the helplessness clearer: if another part of the process had failed, there was even less I could do.

The most draining part was not the journey itself. Each departure required me to carry another expectation. Once there, I might stop for a new reason. Solving the last problem did not guarantee moving a step forward this time. Before one call had returned, I seemed to have entered another level.

I borrow timeouts, packet loss and recursive errors to describe it, not because life follows program logic, but because the feeling was familiar: a request had been sent and no result came back. Try again, and everything had to be explained from the beginning. Impatience could not shorten the system's waiting time.

My emotions made several trips too. First anger, then a degree of numbness. Eventually I learned to prepare only what I could prepare for this attempt. It was not enlightenment. I simply did not want a counter to occupy my entire day, every time.

Some numbers do not arrive just because you apply. They require another counter visit, another document, a wait for the system to recover and another trip. Until, one day, it finally acknowledges that you can be assigned a number.

Chapter 9

# Houston, We Have a Problem: The Rocket That Came Back Scarred

During the winter break, we drove to Space Center Houston. My husband drove; I sat in the passenger seat. For us, accustomed to arranging our days around a small town, it was another extension of our radius. The destination was not an obligation to complete, but somewhere we wanted to see for ourselves.

There, the familiar words Houston, we have a problem no longer belonged only to films and stories. A sentence that admitted a problem could sit alongside the people, equipment and history of working seriously to solve it. Naming a problem did not have to be the beginning of failure.

I remember the scorch marks on the Falcon 9 first stage. It was not the smooth, untouched object I had imagined. The dark marks were unmistakable, impossible to ignore as evidence of what it had been through. Reusability acquired weight in front of the actual thing.

I also touched a moon rock. The contact felt unreal. I was used to knowing distant things through screens. Suddenly one of them was within reach, while I remained an ordinary person trying to understand all the small matters of daily life.

What stayed with me was the rocket that had returned bearing marks. I was always hoping to repair everything and become fully prepared before taking the next step. Yet the object in front of me suggested another kind of reliability: going through trouble and still being able to return and set out again.

That blackened rocket made me feel, for the first time, that continuing with visible traces was not a failure. It could even be a kind of honor.

Chapter 10

# A Thirty-Five-Dollar Specialist Visit: Learning to Read the Body's Log

When my husband had stomach trouble, we began with the campus clinic. As an F1 student, he had a clear entrance to that route of care at the time. We obtained a referral there and then visited an outside gastroenterology practice. The process moved one step at a time.

We met a doctor with a Harvard Medical School background. More than that credential, I remember an appointment that lasted almost an hour. Rather than immediately fitting the discomfort into a conclusion, the doctor asked about symptoms, their timing and possible triggers.

Feelings we usually reduced to one sentence had to be placed back in sequence. When did they begin? Were they constant or intermittent? When were they more noticeable? The body did not organize its own history for us. In the consultation, I realized that describing an experience was a skill to practice.

Medical English suddenly had a purpose quite unlike an exam. It determined whether we could explain the discomfort and understand what the doctor was trying to establish. Understanding a word became more than a small mark of progress. It brought us a little closer to caring for ourselves and each other.

Our out-of-pocket payment for that visit was thirty-five dollars. It was not negligible, but neither was it as alarming as my earlier picture of American healthcare. That amount belonged to that visit, insurance arrangement and route of care. It could not answer for someone else's bill.

The doctor was not a magician. It felt more like someone reading a complicated log from the body. Our part was to make that log as clear as we could.

Chapter 11

# The Little Brown Bottle: Healthcare Ended at the Supermarket Pharmacy

During the consultation, the doctor asked which pharmacy we used. The question made me realize that leaving the examination room would not complete the process. Another part would happen somewhere else in daily life.

The electronic prescription went to the pharmacy, and we went there to collect it. The pharmacy was inside a supermarket, in the same space as ordinary shopping. After the doctor's questions and judgment, the body's discomfort returned to an everyday task: finding a counter.

Name, date of birth, insurance. Again and again, we confirmed who we were and whom the medicine belonged to. By then I had seen many ways systems identified people. These familiar questions became concrete in another way when they concerned the body.

What we finally received was a little brown bottle labeled with a name. Something that had belonged to a consultation was now contained in an object we could take home. A prescription was no longer abstract. It was something to remember, keep safely and use according to its instructions.

I remember the scene not because it was extraordinary, but because it belonged so plainly to daily life. Healthcare could seem enormous and remote. At the end, it still had to settle into a person's name, a set of instructions and the small routines of looking after oneself.

The visit did not end at the hospital. It ended at a small pharmacy counter in the corner of a supermarket.

Chapter 12

# Finding Healthcare on F2: The Next Appointment Was Next Year

When it was my turn to seek care, the route did not unfold like my husband's. Under my circumstances and care arrangements at the time, I could not begin where he had, at the campus clinic. I held my insurance card and started looking for a doctor myself. The card was in my hand; the entrance was not yet in sight.

Finding a doctor meant more than finding a name. It meant calling, asking whether the practice took new patients, whether my insurance could be used and when an appointment might be available. A call could produce an answer, or simply send me to the next number.

One new-patient appointment I was offered was in March of the following year. A small date stretched the wait a long way. I had thought the task was to see a doctor. Now I understood that I first had to find the chance to sit in front of one.

The most frustrating part was having insurance and still not knowing where to go. Being prepared to pay and actually obtaining a service were not two consecutive steps. Between them were new-patient policies, available appointments and many questions I had to know to ask.

Some minor complaints passed during those waits. Their passing did not mean the route had been established, or that waiting would always solve a problem. What stayed with me was how much it mattered to have a reliable entrance when the body needed care.

I thought I was missing a doctor. Later I realized that what I was truly missing was a way in.

Chapter 13

# The Whatever Doctor and the Importance of a PCP

Later, I finally found an appointment only a few days away. I went with the expectation of being received at last. The date was much better than next year, but the experience did not improve along with it. Sitting in the examination room was only the first step.

The doctor's manner felt dismissive. The message about tests seemed to be that having them was fine, and not having them was fine too. I needed explanation and judgment. Instead I felt as though I had been left in front of a menu without knowing how to order.

I did not expect a doctor to take over every decision. But in an unfamiliar field, understanding the options and the reasons for considering them is very different from being asked to pick one immediately. After that visit, I understood more clearly what I wanted from a relationship of care.

Gradually I came to understand the value of a PCP, a primary care physician. For me, it was not only about finding someone temporarily when I was ill. It meant allowing my health to become familiar to someone over time, rather than beginning every visit as an unknown new patient.

Moving from new patient to established patient looked like a small change of category, but it made arranging later appointments easier for me. Building that basic relationship while healthy, and looking for another doctor when the fit was poor, became parts of looking after myself.

A primary care doctor was more than a doctor to me. It was a place to ask for help that I had established in advance, inside an unfamiliar system.

Chapter 14

# Texas State Parks: Bluebonnets, Alligator Marshes and an Armadillo After the Sausages

A friend suggested a Texas State Parks annual pass. We eventually bought one at Somerville State Park. It did not change life all at once, but it gave us reasons to go out repeatedly. Texas began to unfold beyond our home and the routes we took only for errands.

The bluebonnets of March and April marked time differently from bills and appointments. Before, I had often measured the days by the next deadline. Now flowers could mark them too. We returned to parks again and again without needing a major achievement from each visit. Spending some time outside was enough.

The marshes at Brazos Bend held lotus flowers, leaves, waterbirds and alligators. When an alligator remained underwater with only a hint of eyes visible, danger did not present itself as a complete shape. I could not see all of it, but knew it was nearby.

Nature did not become safe and gentle simply because I had come to relax. It offered ease and also reminded me of boundaries. Walking there, I no longer felt I had to see through everything before acknowledging the reality of the world in front of me.

On another camping trip, an armadillo stole sausages in the night. It was funny to tell afterward, but at the time it was a practical lesson. Food could not simply be left outside, and a campsite was not our kitchen with the walls removed. In the wild, our habits needed adjusting.

Texas was no longer only a place for paperwork, doctors and driving tests. It had bluebonnets, marshes, alligators and an armadillo that had made off with sausages in the night.

Chapter 15

# Big Bend: A Leaking Air Mattress Beneath the Milky Way

The drive to Big Bend grew long. Emptiness, cacti, gravel and heat seemed to clear away the familiar background of daily life. An endless road stretched ahead. Even inside the car, I could feel us moving farther from our usual world.

Camping on a budget did not become comfortable merely because the destination was beautiful. Our air mattress began to leak in the middle of the night, making even sleep a problem to handle. There was no power or phone signal that night, only wind and insects to hear. The spaces I usually filled with a screen remained open.

When I looked up, I saw the Milky Way spread across the sky. It did not repair the mattress, and the physical discomfort remained. But discomfort no longer occupied the entire night. Something could be difficult and this moment could be beautiful at the same time. Neither needed to cancel the other.

Small animals wandered near the campsite; I could not tell whether they were coyotes or foxes. I was foolish enough to follow, trying to take photographs. I leave that unwise version of myself in the story. It is something that happened, not an example of how to behave outdoors.

We watched a stark sunset from a mountaintop and saw a mountain lion at a distance. Someone called it a lucky day. Fear and good fortune sat close together in that moment. The wild did not adjust its scale to our expectations, and what we might encounter could not be arranged on an itinerary.

Some people traveled in RVs; others slept on the ground. Outdoor life took different forms. I remember Big Bend not because I planned every step well. Some journeys remain with us through a little discomfort, a little fear and an unexpectedly beautiful moment.

Chapter 16

# Leaving Texas: From a Small Town Toward California

Just as life in Texas was beginning to run smoothly, we were preparing to leave. My husband had an opportunity in California, and an interstate move entered our plans. Places I had spent so long getting to know had to be seen differently: would we take this object, and would we travel this road again?

I could drive. We had found doctors and visited parks. The radius of life had slowly grown, and every outing no longer required preparation from scratch. Some things that once worried me had finally moved into the background and become ordinary routines.

Packing revealed how much life had filled the empty apartment. The first household items had been bought to make living here possible. Now each required another decision about what to do with it. They were more than objects. They marked how we had turned this place into our home.

Leaving did not make the earlier effort feel wasted. A body that could drive, experience in asking questions and a little less panic when something happened would not all disappear at a state line. Still, a new place remained new. I could not carry those skills and pretend I knew the road ahead.

I remembered the blankness of that first reset in Houston. Setting out again was still uncertain. This time, though, I knew a life could be built in small portions and completed gradually. We were leaving without a complete answer, but with some ways to begin again.

We thought we had finally worked out how life in Texas ran. Then life presented another task: leave here and start again.

Afterword

# Not Every Bug Needs Fixing

Some bugs are real problems and need solving. A broken light needs checking, missing documents need supplying and an unwell body needs serious attention. Calling life's difficulties bugs is not a way to make them seem trivial, or to suggest that laughing will make them disappear.

Sometimes, though, the old approach simply cannot work yet. Try another entrance, ask another person or move a plan back a little, and life continues in a different way. Some frustrations never lead to a solution at all. Over time, they become stories that can be told.

When I first arrived in North America, I wanted everything to become stable. I imagined that once we had a home, a license, a car and completed paperwork, life would enter a state without worry. After each task, I waited for that state to arrive.

Eventually I learned that the checklist kept changing. Just as Texas became familiar, California was next. One stretch of road gave way to another. Perhaps stability meant less about keeping change outside than being able to find one or two things I could do when it came.

That has not turned me into someone who is always composed. A new problem can still annoy me, make me hesitate or leave me wishing someone would simply give me an answer. These experiences have only made me more willing to believe that not seeing a way through now does not mean I never will.

We cannot promise that life will not go wrong. But after each error, we can learn to start again. Worst case, a bug.